

Learning Intention: I can build my vocabulary and understand that some words have multiple meanings.

Success Criteria — I can:

- Identify topic-specific vocabulary in a text.
- Explain that some words have more than one meaning.
- Use context clues to work out which meaning is intended.

Reading Strategy

Some words have more than one meaning — these are called **multiple-meaning words**. To work out which meaning is being used, look at the other words around it. This is called using **context clues**.

Read — The Same Word, Different Meanings

Many English words have more than one meaning. The word **bat** can mean a small flying mammal that comes out at night, or a piece of sports equipment used to hit a ball. The word **bank** can mean a place where people keep their money, or the sloped land beside a river.

The word **spring** is even trickier — it can mean the season after winter, a coiled piece of metal that bounces back into shape, or a place where water naturally flows up from the ground.

How do readers know which meaning is meant? They look at the **context** — the other words in the sentence. In "The bat swooped through the dark cave," the words swooped and dark cave tell us it's the flying animal, not the sports equipment.

Model — Multiple-Meaning Words

Word	Meaning 1	Meaning 2
Bat	Flying nocturnal mammal	Sports equipment for hitting a ball
Bank	Place to keep money	Land beside a river
Spring	Season after winter	Coiled metal / water source

Parent Tip

Play a quick game together — take turns saying a multiple-meaning word (like "bark", "light" or "trunk") and see who can name both meanings first.

Try It

Think of a sentence using the word "bank" to mean a river bank, not a place to keep money. Write it here:

Find It, Think About It & Apply

Q1 — Which Meaning?

Read each sentence. Write which meaning of the bold word is being used.

Sentence	Meaning used
We sat on the grassy bank and watched the ducks.	
Dad deposited his pay cheque at the bank .	
A bat flew silently over the campsite at dusk.	

Q2 — Write Two Meanings

Choose one word from the box. Write two sentences using it with two different meanings.

Word bank: trunk · light · ring · wave

Word chosen: _____

Sentence 1 (meaning 1): _____

Sentence 2 (meaning 2): _____

Q3 — Topic-Specific Vocabulary

Sort these words into the correct topic.

Words: habitat · goalkeeper · predator · whistle · ecosystem · penalty

Science Topic Words	Sport Topic Words

Q4 — Choose the Correct Meaning

Circle the correct meaning for the bold word, based on the sentence.

- a) The gymnast did a **spring** off the diving board. — season / bounce-jump / water source
 b) We planted new flowers in **spring**. — season / bounce-jump / water source
 c) The old mattress had a broken **spring**. — season / coiled metal / water source

Watch Out!

Never guess a word's meaning from how it looks alone — always check the **context** (the surrounding words) to be sure which meaning fits.

Q5 — True or False?

Statement	True / False
A word can only ever have one correct meaning.	True / False
Context clues help you decide which meaning of a word is intended.	True / False

Apply & Reasoning — Use what you've learned to explain your thinking.

- 1 Reasoning:** Why is it important to check the context of a sentence before deciding what a word means?

- 2 Reasoning:** Explain why learning topic-specific vocabulary (like science or sport words) helps you understand a text better.

- 3 Create:** Choose a multiple-meaning word of your own (not already used in this worksheet). Write its two meanings, then write one sentence for each meaning.

Quick Check — Exit Ticket

Write one sentence using the word "light" to mean "not heavy", and one sentence using it to mean "a source of brightness".

Answer & Teacher Support

Answer Key — Pages 1 & 2

Try It (p1): Accept any sentence correctly using "bank" as land beside a river.

Q1 (p2): Grassy bank — land beside a river. Pay cheque bank — place to keep money. Bat at dusk — flying animal.

Q2 (p2): Accept any two correct, clearly different-meaning sentences for the chosen word.

Q3 (p2): Science: habitat, predator, ecosystem. Sport: goalkeeper, whistle, penalty.

Q4 (p2): a) bounce-jump. b) season. c) coiled metal.

Q5 (p2): "Word can only have one meaning" — False. "Context clues help decide meaning" — True.

Answer Key — Page 3

Q1: Without checking context, a reader might pick the wrong meaning and misunderstand the whole sentence.

Q2: Topic-specific vocabulary carries important meaning within that subject area, so knowing it helps readers fully understand what a text is explaining.

Q3 (acceptable-answer guide): Accept any genuine multiple-meaning word with two accurate meanings and two correctly matching sentences.

Exit ticket: Accept any two sentences correctly demonstrating both meanings of "light" (weight vs brightness).

Teacher Checklist

- ☐ Identifies the correct meaning of a word using context.
- ☐ Writes two sentences showing different meanings of one word.
- ☐ Sorts topic-specific vocabulary correctly.
- ☐ Explains why context matters for word meaning.
- ☐ Independently identifies and uses a new multiple-meaning word.

Teacher Tip

Multiple-meaning words are a common source of comprehension confusion, especially for EAL/D students. Keep a running class list of multiple-meaning words discovered during other reading and content-area lessons throughout the term.